

Making a function

The best functions have a clear purpose and a good name that explains what they do – think of the `check_guess()` function you used in Animal Quiz. Follow these instructions to create, or “define”, a function that calculates the number of seconds in a day and then prints the answer on the screen.

The keyword `def` tells Python that this block of code is a function.

The lines after the name must be indented 4 spaces, to show Python that they are part of the function.

This command calls the function.

1 Define the function

Create a new file in IDLE. Save it as “functions.py”. Type these lines into the editor window. An indent is added at the start of each line in the function. Save the file again, then run the code to see what happens.

```
def print_seconds_per_day():
    hours = 24
    minutes = hours * 60
    seconds = minutes * 60
    print(seconds)
```

The name of the function

There are no parameters yet.

Variables

This line prints the value of the variable `seconds`.

`print_seconds_per_day()`

86400

The number of seconds in a day appears in the shell.

FUNCTIONS

EXPERT TIPS

Top advice

It's important to define your functions before you use them in your main code. When you're learning to code with Python, it's helpful to put your functions at the top of your file, after any import statements. By doing this, you won't make the mistake of trying to call a function before you've defined it.

2 Add parameters

If you want to give your function any values to work with, you put them inside the brackets as parameters. For example, to find out the total number of seconds in a particular number of days, change your code to look like this. The function now has the parameter `days`. You can specify the number of days when you call the function. Try it out yourself.

```
def print_seconds_per_day(days):
    hours = days * 24
    minutes = hours * 60
    seconds = minutes * 60
    print(seconds)
```

The function's parameter

This line uses the parameter `days`.

Gives a value (7) to the parameter `days`

`print_seconds_per_day(7)`

604800

The number of seconds in 7 days

Existing lines of code are shown in grey and new lines of code in bold.